

Case Study: The "Urgent Electricity Disconnection" UPI Scam

The Crime: UPI fraud typically involves tricking people into authorising transfers they never intended. One common version is the "electricity disconnection" scam. It uses a sense of urgency to pressure victims into handing over their money.

How it happens:

- * The victim gets an SMS saying their electricity will be cut off at 9:30 PM because their billing profile isn't up to date. The message includes a "help desk" number to call right away.
- * Worried about losing power, the victim calls the number. On the other end is a fraudster pretending to be a utility company employee.
- * The scammer then advises the victim to install a remote screen-sharing app, like AnyDesk or TeamViewer, claiming it's necessary to fix the system error.
- * Once the app is running, the scammer asks the victim to make a small payment of ₹10 through their UPI app to "verify the connection." As the victim enters their 4- or 6-digit UPI PIN, the scammer watches via screen share, capturing it in real-time. They then use that PIN to approve much larger unauthorised transactions, emptying the victim's bank accounts.
- * This trick mainly preys on elderly people, busy professionals, or anyone less familiar with how digital security really works. The scammers bank on panic to stop victims from thinking clearly.

The losses are often immediate and hard to recover from. Many victims also face anxiety, shame, and a lasting hesitation to trust online banking or payments again.